

will appear on the mask's thumbnail and the effect of the mask will now vanish from the layer. To get it back, [Shift] + left-click the thumbnail once again.

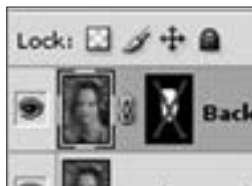
The layer mask in the main document window

We've discussed how layer masks create new Alpha channels for the image—you can see this new channel in the Channels palette. By default, the channel's visibility is turned off (there is no "eye" icon next to the thumbnail). However, it sometimes becomes a little annoying to have to edit masks and judge the outcome based on the corresponding layer.

To see the mask itself in the document window, turn on the visibility of the channel in the Channels palette. The mask will now appear in the main document window as a 50% transparent red layer. You can change this appearance if you want by right-clicking on the mask's thumbnail and selecting Layer Mask Options.

Gradient masks

Like we said before, the great thing about masks is that they can be treated like normal layers, and this means that we can even apply gradients to them. When you apply a gradient to a mask, you end up with a very interesting fade-out effect for the layer—the white part is completely opaque, the black part is completely transparent, and the intermediate areas fade according to the intensity of white or black.



The "X" means that the mask is disabled



Turn on the mask's channel visibility to see it in the document



A Gradient mask